MUSIC

A New Set of Strings

Former tennis star Somdev Devvarman puts on his singing hat with his solo album *One Three Two*

Around the same time that Somdev Devvarman began tennis lessons, he also took guitar classes. Starting at the age of nine, Devvarman recalls, "I took lessons for like three months and then tennis took over." Even as tennis took him around the world and made him a sports idol, Devvarman retired in 2017 and turned his focus to being on broadcast TV and coaching as well. The same year, he and a friend went to see UK pop artist Ed Sheeran perform in Washington D.C.

Devvarman recalls how Sheeran spoke about encouraging every closeted musician to "get out there and play". It struck a chord with him, and he wrote his first song, 'New Man', that same night, which he says put into words his feelings about leaving behind tournaments and the rigour of training, but not in a glorified way. In a breezy yet resolute way, Devvarman sings about being in the midst of a different energy and how something is missing, but eventually admitting that it's time to let go. He adds, "Once that song was complete, in terms of structuring and arrangements, I found that to be fun. And then I just kept going."

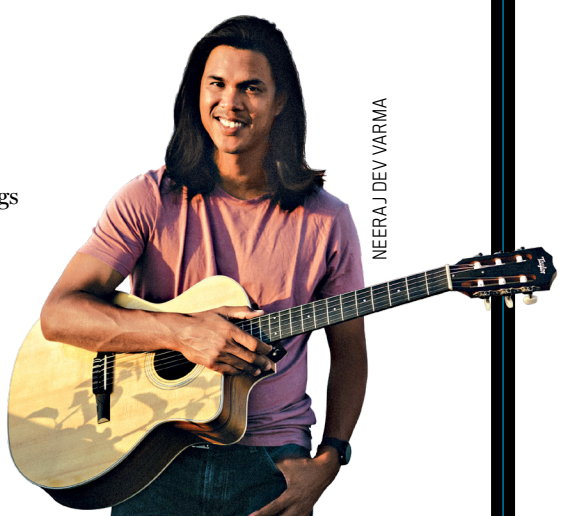
Devvarman wrote five songs in that same week, and years later—in 2023 to be precise—he brought in his 38th birthday on February 13 by releasing his debut solo album *One Three Two* via the Chennai artist platform Original Dog. Thirteen songs are spread across side A and side B, as a nod to Devvarman's love for cassettes. Influenced by the likes of Dave Matthews, Frightened Rabbit and Jack Johnson, *One Three Two* is a lazy day listen that isn't preachy as much as it is about friendly advice and wisdom, with a warm tone. But that's just for the length of the first seven tracks on side A.

The tone changes towards the end of side A with "One More Night" and brings in fuller, gradually building rock songs like "Different Kind of Day" and "Below the Mistletoe", which he wrote for his wife. Elsewhere, songs like "The Seeker" are steeped in Devvarman's philosophical thoughts, and he touches upon autism and socio-political strife in "Ode to Justice". He has not tried to force perfection as much as he has aimed for honesty. "There were not really any very wrong answers ... I felt the kind of artistic freedom that I've never felt in my life. That was one of the most fulfilling things that I've ever done," says Devvarman.

In *One Three Two*, Devvarman has tried not to force perfection as much as he's aimed for honesty

It's the start of a new chapter with *One Three Two* and Devvarman says he'll be promoting the record more, plus taking on performances. Being an independent artist, he says, is a learning curve. "There are many things I know I can do better, but I'm enjoying the process." ■

Anurag Tagat



NEERAJ DEV VARMA



NO HURDLE TOO HIGH

SPORTS

WITH HER SILVER WIN IN ASIAN INDOORS THIS MONTH, **ACE ATHLETE JYOTHI YARRAJI** CONTINUES TO BREAK HER OWN RECORDS

Suresh Menon has for years been known for his cricket stories in *Deccan Herald* and *Indian Express*, as editor of *Wisden India Almanack*, and as an author of books on cricket. In *Why Don't You Write Something I Might Read?*, he explores his other interest: English literature.

Through some brief 40 essays, interspersed with two-page "short takes", Menon discusses New Journalism (Tom Wolfe was "a cult figure rather than the father of a school of writing"), New Age Writing (Is Paulo Coelho "merely Chetan Bhagat in a different accent?"), and book reviews ("The sensible procedure for a critic," as W.H. Auden says, "is to keep silent about works which he believes to be bad"). He also covers crime, sex, and the writer as an alcoholic.

There are interesting nuggets strewn throughout the slim volume: V.S. Naipaul stuns Menon with his photographic memory, recalling the fish curry he ate at